to respond, gave the order to stop preparations for firing." Although the torpedo was ready to be fired, it remained in its tube.[21]

"Savitsky," wrote Slaughter long afterward, when he had learned the Soviet commander's name, "acknowledged my apology and closed his torpedo-tube doors. He wheeled to port and returned to his easterly heading. I was greatly relieved not to be staring down the barrel of B-59's torpedo tubes." "When things settled down, Morgan gave me my standing orders in the language of a sailor: 'Keep that Russian bastard happy,' " recalled Slaughter. "I did just that. I nodded my thanks for Savitsky's patience. The Russian even nodded back. Our relationship appeared slightly more cordial."[22]

Although they did not know it at the time, the seamen of the USS *Cony* and other ships of the *Randolph* group were moments away from being killed or shipwrecked by the tremendous waves that a nuclear explosion would produce. Savitsky's torpedo carried a warhead with 10 kilotons of explosive power. If dropped on a city, that would suffice to kill everyone within a half-mile radius. Moreover, the torpedoes' nuclear warheads were designed to create shock waves that would topple or incapacitate ships. The 20-kiloton load tried by the US Navy in the Baker underwater test in 1946 produced waves up to 94 feet high. The Soviets tested their T-5 torpedoes near Novaia Zemlia in the Arctic in 1957 but never released the results. Any ship hit by the torpedo would almost certainly have been destroyed, while the rest of the *Randolph* group would have suffered significant damage.[23]

The political consequences of a nuclear attack in the Sargasso Sea would have been even more significant. "It shall be the policy of this nation to regard any nuclear missile launched from Cuba against any nation in the Western Hemisphere as an attack on the United States, requiring a full retaliatory response upon the Soviet Union," declared Kennedy in his television address on October 22. In response to a nuclear attack on the US Navy, the president would have had little choice but to order an air strike against Soviet targets. The Soviets would have had little choice but to retaliate, whether they wanted to do so or not.[24]